implied I was a racist, the worst in the White House since Herbert Hoover. A meeting was arranged between the two of us.

We spoke for an hour or so upstairs in the family quarters, and I literally told him my life story—how Jack and Nelle had raised me from the time I was a child to believe racial and religious discrimination was the worst sin in the world, how I'd experienced some of it as the son of an Irish Catholic in a Protestant town; how as a sports announcer I'd been among the first in the country to campaign for integration of professional baseball; how I'd tried as governor to open up opportunities for blacks. That night, I think I made a friend.

As the adjutant of my Army Air Corps post during the war, I'd had the responsibility to call the parents of combat cameramen who had been killed in action and tell them their sons wouldn't be returning from the war. I learned then that there is not much you can say to comfort people in such a situation, but you have to try. All I could do was tell them how much they had to be proud of, and that we had to believe God's promise that one day we will all be united with our loved ones.

As president, I frequently had to speak to the families of men and women who had died in the service of their country. Because of what I'd done during the war, it wasn't a new experience; but it was not one I ever got used to, and this responsibility, this weight on my shoulders, felt like a ton of iron.

On a tragic day in January 1986, after my usual staff meetings, I began the morning with a conference with congressional leaders from both parties at which I had a few words with Tip O'Neill over my continuing (and still frustrated) efforts to cut federal spending. Then Alaska Senator Frank Murkowski brought in a family of his constituents he wanted me to meet. Next came a briefing from Larry Speakes, the acting press secretary. I was